DIGITALKARTAI.SHOP | 2026-27 EDITION

The Indian Consumer Rights & Refund Playbook

How to complain, escalate and get your money back - from banks, telecoms, e-commerce, airlines, builders, insurers, hospitals and more.

The new RBI Ombudsman Scheme 2026. The National Consumer Helpline. e-Jagriti consumer courts. Sector ombudsmen. Ready-to-send letters. The escalation ladder that actually gets results.

Every rule, fee, deadline and portal verified from official Government of India sources - October 2026.

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Each part is built to be used on its own. If you are in a hurry, jump straight to the sector that matches your problem in Part 4, or use the escalation ladder in Part 2.

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How to use this playbook

You do not need a lawyer, a fee or a court visit to get most consumer problems fixed in India. You need three things: the right forum, a clean paper trail, and a deadline. This playbook gives you all three.

The system has four rungs, and most people stop at rung one - which is exactly why they fail. Rung one is the seller. Rung two is the free National Consumer Helpline, which in 2025 handled over 17.7 lakh complaints and helped return over Rs. 91 crore to consumers. Rung three is a free sector ombudsman - the RBI for banks, IRDAI for insurance. Rung four is the consumer commission, where you can file online through e-Jagriti and, for claims up to Rs. 5 lakh, pay no fee at all.

The 60-second version

1. **Write, do not call.** Every complaint starts as a written message to the seller's grievance officer. Email is the cheapest proof you will ever create.
2. **Give a deadline.** Ask for a resolution within 15 days and say what you will do next if it does not come.
3. **Keep the receipt.** Save the order number, invoice, screenshots, chats and the acknowledgement. A complaint without evidence is a story; with evidence it is a case.
4. **Escalate on time.** When the deadline passes, move up a rung the same day. Delay is how cases die - the consumer court has a two-year limit, and ombudsmen have even shorter windows.
5. **Claim what the law allows.** Refund, replacement, compensation for the loss and mental agony, and the cost of the complaint. Ask for all of it in writing.

The golden rules

1. One issue per complaint. Mixing a refund claim with a rude-staff complaint weakens both.
2. Written only. Keep a dated file for every complaint, in one folder, on your phone and in email.
3. Escalate in writing and say which rung you are moving to next.
4. Never accept a verbal promise. Ask for it by email.
5. The forum is free at rungs two and three. Do not pay any 'agent' who offers to file for you.

What this playbook is not

This is a practical, plain-English guide to India's consumer redressal system, built from official Government of India sources and current as of October 2026. It is not legal advice, and it is not a substitute for a lawyer on a large or complex dispute. Rules, portals and phone numbers change; where a figure or deadline matters to your case, confirm it on the official portal named in that section before you rely on it.

PART ONE

Your rights, and the law that backs them

If you bought a product or paid for a service for personal use, you are a consumer - and India's consumer law gives you a free, three-tier system to enforce your rights. The law is on your side far more often than most people realise.

What makes you a 'consumer'

The Consumer Protection Act, 2019 defines a consumer as a person who buys goods or hires or avails services for a consideration. That includes online purchases, insurance policies, bank services, phone connections, coaching classes, hospital treatment, travel bookings and food delivery. It covers you whether you bought the product new, or it was bought by someone else and gifted to you. It also covers a person who uses a service with the buyer's approval.

There is one important carve-out: goods bought or services hired for a commercial purpose - to resell, or to use in a business for profit - are not covered. A shopkeeper buying stock to resell is not a consumer; a home baker buying a mixer for her own kitchen is.

The six rights the Act gives you

- **Right to safety** - protection against goods and services that are hazardous to life and property.
- **Right to be informed** - to be told the quality, quantity, potency, purity, standard and price, so you can make an informed choice.
- **Right to choose** - access to a variety of goods and services at competitive prices.
- **Right to be heard** - your complaint must be given due consideration.
- **Right to seek redressal** - to get a refund, replacement or compensation for unfair or restrictive trade practices.
- **Right to consumer education** - to be taught about your rights and remedies.

The practices the law targets

The Act gives you remedies against three specific kinds of behaviour, and knowing their names helps you frame a complaint.

- **Unfair trade practice** - a deceptive practice to promote a sale: a false claim about a product's quality, a fake discount, a hidden charge, a misleading advertisement, or refusing to take back a defective product.
- **Restrictive trade practice** - one that forces you to buy something extra to get the thing you actually want, or ties a sale to conditions you did not agree to.
- **Unfair contract** - a one-sided term in a standard-form contract (the fine print nobody negotiates) that unfairly favours the seller - for example, an absolute 'no refunds under any circumstance' clause, or a term that lets the seller change the deal after you have paid.

Product liability: when the harm is bigger than the money

The Act added a product liability chapter. A manufacturer, product seller or product service provider can be held liable for any harm caused by a defective product, a deficient service, or a failure to warn about risks. This is separate from, and larger than, a simple refund claim - it is the route for injury, damage or serious loss caused by a product.

Who enforces this: the CCPA

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) is the regulator that acts for consumers as a class. It can investigate, order a company to recall a product or refund buyers, stop a misleading advertisement, and run class actions. For a false or misleading advertisement, the CCPA can fine a manufacturer or endorser up to Rs. 10 lakh, and up to Rs. 50 lakh for a repeat offence; an endorser can be banned from endorsing for up to one year. The CCPA came into being on 24 July 2020; as of 9 March 2026 it had issued 477 class-action notices and imposed penalties of Rs. 3,00,40,500.

Rs. 10 lakh
CCPA first-offence fine
For a false or misleading advertisement by a manufacturer or endorser.

Rs. 50 lakh
Repeat-offence fine
For every subsequent contravention of the same kind.

3 tiers
District, State, National
The consumer commission hierarchy that hears your case.

Where Indians complain the most

The helpline's sector data for FY 2025-26 shows where the pain is concentrated - and where the system is most practised at fixing it. If your problem sits in the top few rows, the free route is likely to work.

Sector	Complaints in FY 2025-26
E-Commerce	5,77,748
Food	1,04,218
Consumer Durables	93,733
Electronics Products	89,787
Telecom	84,429
NBFCs	71,226
Automobiles	70,816
Agency Services	69,477
Banking	64,320
Travel & Tourism	62,698

Source: National Consumer Helpline sector-wise data, FY 2025-26 (Lok Sabha replies, 2026).

The 2026 reset: what changed this year

Three changes in 2026 make the system faster and stronger than it was even a year ago, and you should build your complaint around them.

- **The RBI Ombudsman Scheme 2026** came into force on 1 July 2026, replacing the 2021 scheme. It keeps the 'One Nation One Ombudsman' model and the free centralised portal at cms.rbi.org.in.
- **The Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026** were notified on 9 September 2026 and take effect from 1 January 2027. They make it mandatory for every e-commerce entity to join the National Consumer Helpline convergence programme, and add new duties on search results, sponsored listings, price display, dark patterns and seller disclosure.
- **e-Jagriti**, the unified online consumer-commission platform, replaced the older CONFONET system on 1 January 2025 and now handles filing, notices, hearings and orders in one place.

Your rights in practice

Here is how the rights above map onto the problems you are most likely to face.

When this happens	Right breached	Your first move
A seller refuses to take back a defective product	Right to seek redressal	Written complaint to the seller, then the NCH
An advertisement claims what a product cannot deliver	Right to be informed; unfair trade practice	Report to the CCPA and the NCH
You are forced to buy an add-on to get what you want	Restrictive trade practice	Complaint to the consumer commission
A standard contract strips your right to a refund	Unfair contract	Challenge the term inside your complaint
A product causes injury or damage	Right to safety; product liability	Preserve the product and proof; approach the commission
Your complaint is simply ignored	Right to be heard	Escalate to the NCH, then the commission

Why the timing matters

Every rung of the ladder has a clock. The consumer court gives you two years from the date the problem arose. The RBI Ombudsman wants your complaint within 90 days of the bank's failure to respond. The Insurance Ombudsman wants it within one year. Miss the clock and a strong case becomes a weak one - so file early, and escalate the moment a deadline passes.

PART TWO

The four-rung escalation ladder

Most complaints fail at rung one because people stop there. The system is designed so that each rung creates a written record that makes the next rung easier - and cheaper - to win.

Rung 1: The seller's grievance officer

This is where every complaint must start, because every higher forum will ask whether you gave the company a chance to fix it first. Send a written complaint (email is best) to the company's grievance officer or customer-care address. State the order or account number, the problem in three sentences, the exact remedy you want, and a deadline - 15 days is reasonable. Keep the acknowledgement.

Useful deadlines that the rules themselves set:

- An e-commerce entity must acknowledge your complaint within 48 hours and resolve it within one month.
- An insurer must resolve your grievance within 14 days.
- A bank or regulated financial entity gets 30 days before you may go to the RBI Ombudsman.
- An airline must route your grievance through its nodal officer and appellate authority.

Rung 2: The National Consumer Helpline

The NCH is the government's free, pre-litigation grievance system. It is fast, it works in 17 languages, and over 1,850 companies have agreed to answer complaints that come through it directly. In 2025 it received 17,71,622 complaints and disposed of every one; in 2025-26 it received and closed 20,48,747, with an average disposal time of 28 days. Between 25 April 2025 and 30 June 2026 it helped return over Rs. 91 crore to consumers. Part 3 is a full walkthrough.

Rung 3: The sector regulator or ombudsman

For money and regulated services, a dedicated free forum usually beats the general helpline. Banks and NBFCs go to the RBI Ombudsman. Insurers go to the IRDAI's Bima Bharosa and then the Insurance Ombudsman. Investments go to SEBI's SCORES. These bodies can order a refund and, in many cases, compensation - and they charge nothing.

Rung 4: The consumer commission

When the free routes fail or the amount is large, you file a formal complaint online through e-Jagriti. The commission can order a refund, replacement, compensation for loss and mental agony, and the cost of your complaint. Claims up to Rs. 5 lakh cost nothing to file, and you can argue your own case.

The ladder at a glance

Rung	Forum	Cost	Typical clock	Best for
1	Seller / grievance officer	Free	48 hrs to 30 days	Every complaint - the mandatory first step
2	National Consumer Helpline	Free	Minutes to file, ~28 days average	E-commerce, food, retail, fast refunds
3	Sector ombudsman / regulator	Free	14 to 90 days	Banks, insurance, investments, telecom
4	Consumer commission (e-Jagriti)	Free up to Rs. 5 lakh	Months	Larger claims, stubborn sellers, compensation

When to skip a rung

You may go straight to a higher rung in three situations. If the amount is small and the seller is unresponsive, jump to the NCH rather than waiting weeks. If a bank has already ignored you for 30 days, go to the RBI Ombudsman directly. If a builder has delayed possession for months and the project is RERA-registered, file with the state RERA - it is faster than a court and can order interest for every month of delay.

Which forum for which problem

Use this map to skip straight to the right door. It saves days of guessing.

If your problem is...	Start with	Then escalate to
Something bought online	The platform's grievance officer	NCH, then consumer commission
A bank, UPI, card or loan	Your bank's nodal officer	RBI Ombudsman, then consumer commission
An insurance claim or policy	The insurer's Grievance Redressal Officer	Bima Bharosa, then Insurance Ombudsman
A phone, internet or DTH bill	Your operator	Its nodal and appellate officers, then TRAI
A flight problem	The airline's nodal officer	AirSewa, then consumer commission
A delayed flat or builder	Your state RERA (Section 31)	Consumer commission
An investment or broker issue	The company or broker	SEBI SCORES 2.0
A restaurant or packaged food	The seller	FSSAI and the NCH
Money taken by fraud	Dial 1930 and cybercrime.gov.in	Your bank, then the RBI Ombudsman
A government service	The department concerned	CPGRAMS at pgportal.gov.in

The two rules that decide most cases

Write everything. A phone call proves nothing. An email with a read receipt proves a date.
Escalate on the deadline, not on your mood. Set a reminder the day your 15-day or 30-day window closes and act that day. Momentum is the whole game.

PART THREE

The National Consumer Helpline: India's fastest free fix

The NCH is the single best first escalation for most consumer problems in India. It is free, it is fast, and because it routes your complaint to companies that have agreed to respond, a large share of disputes end here - without a court, a lawyer or a fee.

17.7 lakh
Complaints in 2025
Every one disposed of by the helpline.

Rs. 91 Cr+
Refunds facilitated
Between 25 Apr 2025 and 30 Jun 2026.

28 days
Average disposal time
For FY 2025-26, down from 63 days in FY 2023-24.

What the NCH is, and what it is not

The NCH is a pre-litigation grievance platform run by the Department of Consumer Affairs. It registers your complaint, gives you a docket number, and pushes it to the company - either directly, if the company is a 'convergence' partner, or by forwarding it. It cannot itself order a refund or fine anyone; that power belongs to the CCPA, the commissions and the sector regulators. But its leverage is real, and its numbers prove it: grievance registration has grown from an average of 37,062 a month in 2017 to over 1,97,000 a month in 2026.

The sector where it wins most is e-commerce. Of the 17,71,622 complaints received in 2025, 5,11,196 - about 29 per cent - were about e-commerce, and over Rs. 63 crore of the refunds facilitated came from the e-commerce sector alone.

Every way to reach the NCH

Channel	Detail
Toll-free phone	1915, or 1800 11 4000 - daily except national holidays, 8 AM to 8 PM
WhatsApp / SMS	8800001915 (the fastest-growing channel - a fifth of all complaints by end-2025)
Web portal	consumerhelpline.gov.in (registration and grievance in one place)
NCH mobile app	Register, upload documents and track status
UMANG app	Search 'Consumer Affairs' or 'National Consumer Helpline'
Email	nch-ca@gov.in
Languages	17, including Hindi, English, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam and more

How to file on the portal (step by step)

1. Go to consumerhelpline.gov.in and register with your mobile number and email.
2. Choose 'Register Grievance'. Select your state and city, then the sector (for example, E-Commerce), the category, and the company name.
3. Describe the problem in plain words - what you bought, what went wrong, the order number, and what you want.
4. Upload your evidence: the invoice, screenshots of the order, and the chat or email trail.
5. Submit and note the docket number. You will get SMS and email updates.

How to file on WhatsApp (the 60-second route)

1. Save 8800001915 and send it a message, or scan the NCH QR code to open the chat.
2. Specify your state, city, sector, grievance category and the company name when asked.
3. Give the full details of the grievance and upload the relevant documents in the chat.
4. You receive a docket number when every step is complete.

The 48-hour and one-month clock

Once an e-commerce company is a convergence partner, it is required to acknowledge your complaint within 48 hours and redress it within one month - and, since the 2026 amendment, to give you a copy of the complaint as its grievance officer recorded it. If a month passes with no fair result, that silence is itself evidence for your next rung.

Why NCH complaints stall - and how to avoid it

- The complaint is vague. 'Bad service' cannot be acted on; 'the product arrived cracked and the refund was refused' can.
- There is no proof. Attach the invoice and screenshots. A claim without evidence gets a polite no.
- It is aimed at the wrong company. Complain against the seller named on your invoice, and name the platform too if you bought on a marketplace.
- The ask is unclear. Say exactly what you want - a refund of Rs. X, a replacement, or compensation.
- The follow-up is missing. If a docket sits idle, reply on the same thread and quote the docket number.

What to say in an NCH complaint

Keep it factual and short. A good complaint has four parts: the transaction (what, when, order number, amount paid); the failure (what the company did or failed to do); the proof (what documents you are attaching); and the ask (refund of Rs. X, replacement, or compensation of Rs. Y). End with the date. Do not write an essay and do not use abuse - both weaken the file.

PART FOUR

Sector playbooks: where to complain, and how

The right forum depends on what you bought. This part gives you the exact portal, the exact deadline and the exact first step for the twelve sectors where Indians complain the most.

E-commerce and quick commerce

Start with the platform's grievance officer, then the NCH, then the consumer commission. E-commerce is the most complained-about sector in India, and the rules are firmly on your side.

Your rights under the E-Commerce Rules, 2020 (as amended)

- Every e-commerce entity must display its legal name, address, website and the contact details of its customer care and grievance officer.
- The grievance officer must acknowledge your complaint within 48 hours, give you a copy of the recorded complaint, and redress it within one month.
- Sellers must disclose return, refund, exchange, warranty, delivery and payment terms, and the country of origin for imported goods.
- Your consent must be taken by explicit, affirmative action - never by pre-ticked checkboxes.
- Prices must not be manipulated to gain unreasonable profit, and platforms must not discriminate between consumers of the same class.

What the 2026 amendment adds (from 1 January 2027)

- Every e-commerce entity must become a partner in the NCH convergence programme - it is no longer optional.
- Search results must not be manipulated to mislead you, and sponsored listings must be clearly labelled.
- When a discount is announced, both the reduced price and the 'prior price' - the lowest price in the 30 days before the announcement - must be shown.
- The invoice must display the seller's name in the same font size as the platform's own name.
- Platforms must comply with the Dark Patterns Guidelines, 2023, run a yearly self-audit, and display a compliance certificate.
- Bundled fees for services unrelated to the platform are prohibited, except in loyalty programmes.

The e-commerce playbook

1. Photograph the product the moment it arrives, before you open any packaging. This one habit wins a large share of disputes.
2. Raise a return or refund request in-app and screenshot the request and the response.
3. Email the grievance officer with the order number, the problem and the remedy, asking for a reply within 48 hours.
4. If the reply is unhelpful or missing, file on the NCH the same week.
5. If a month passes, file with the consumer commission - you can claim the refund plus compensation for the delay.

The e-commerce evidence pack

Invoice and order confirmation; photographs of the product on arrival; screenshots of the listing as it looked when you bought; the in-app return or refund request and its response; and your email to the grievance officer with the date. These five items win most e-commerce disputes.

Dark patterns: the traps the law now names

The CCPA's Dark Patterns Guidelines, 2023 list 13 practices that trick you into doing something you did not intend. Spotting them is half the battle: false urgency ('only 2 left!' when there are hundreds), confirm-shaming ('no thanks, I like paying more'), drip pricing (a low price that grows at checkout), subscription traps (free trial that will not cancel), disguised advertisements, and preselected add-ons. If a platform used one, say so by name in your complaint - it is now a compliance breach.

Banking, UPI, cards and loans

Go to the bank first, then the RBI Ombudsman. Banking complaints are free to escalate and the RBI's 2026 scheme is unusually consumer-friendly.

Step 1: The bank's own grievance redressal

Complain in writing to your bank's branch or its nodal officer and get an acknowledgement with a complaint number. The bank must resolve it, and you must wait 30 days (or the timeline the RBI, NPCI or card network sets, whichever is longer) before going to the Ombudsman - unless you have a reply you are unhappy with, in which case you can escalate immediately.

Step 2: The RBI Ombudsman (RB-IOS, 2026)

- The Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2026 came into force on 1 July 2026. It is free and it follows a 'One Nation One Ombudsman' model - you do not need to go to a particular office.
- File online at cms.rbi.org.in, by email to crpc@rbi.org.in, or by post to the Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre, Reserve Bank of India, Central Vista, Sector 17, Chandigarh - 160017.
- File within 90 days of the bank's failure to reply or of its unsatisfactory reply.
- Call the RBI Contact Centre on toll-free 14448 (24x7 IVRS; staff 8 AM to 10 PM, Monday to Saturday) for guidance - but you cannot file a complaint over the phone.
- No fee. You may file through an authorised representative (not an advocate, unless the advocate is the aggrieved person).

What the RBI Ombudsman covers - and what it does not

It covers all commercial banks, regional rural banks, urban co-operative banks above a deposit-size threshold, most NBFCs with customer interface, prepaid wallet issuers, and credit information companies. It does not cover housing finance companies, core investment companies, or disputes that are purely a bank's commercial judgement. Common winning grounds: unauthorised or wrong UPI transfers, a card transaction you did not make, a loan charge you did not agree to, a failure to update your credit report after a correction, and mis-sold insurance bundled with a loan.

The banking evidence pack

Account or card statement with the disputed entry highlighted; the transaction reference number; the bank's complaint acknowledgement and complaint number; screenshots of any app notification or chat; and your written complaint with the date you sent it. If you have all six, an RBI Ombudsman complaint is close to unanswerable.

Zero liability on unauthorised transactions

If you report an unauthorised card or account transaction promptly, RBI rules limit your liability - report within three working days and your liability is generally zero. Report to the bank at once, then get the written acknowledgement, then escalate to the Ombudsman if the bank drags its feet.

Insurance: make them pay

Insurers reject claims, delay them and mis-sell policies. You have two free escalation routes - IRDAI's Bima Bharosa and the Insurance Ombudsman - and a clear order in which to use them.

1. **The insurer's Grievance Redressal Officer (GRO).** Every branch has one. Complain in writing with documents and take a written acknowledgement. The insurer must resolve it within 14 days.
2. **IRDAI's Bima Bharosa.** If 14 days pass, or you are unhappy with the reply, register on bimabharosa.irdai.gov.in, or call 155255 / 1800 425 4732, or email complaints@irdai.gov.in. There is no monetary limit on a Bima Bharosa complaint.
3. **The Insurance Ombudsman.** A free, quasi-judicial forum. File within one year of the rejection or of one month of no reply. Compensation sought must not exceed Rs. 50 lakh. The award is binding on the insurer, which must comply within 30 days - but it is not binding on you.

There are 17 Insurance Ombudsman centres: Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Bhopal, Bhubaneswar, Chandigarh, Chennai, Delhi, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Kochi, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai, Noida, Patna and Pune. The Ombudsman must pass an award within three months of receiving everything it needs. You cannot go to the Ombudsman if the same matter is already pending or decided before a court or consumer forum.

The insurance evidence pack

The policy schedule and the full policy wording; the proposal form you filled in; the claim form and every document you submitted; the insurer's rejection or query letter; your written representation to the Grievance Redressal Officer; and any medical or repair records that bear on the claim.

How to rebut the three most common rejections

- **'Non-disclosure of pre-existing disease.'** Check whether the insurer asked the specific question and whether the disease falls within the waiting period. If the policy is older than the moratorium period (typically 60 months for health cover), the insurer generally cannot reject on non-disclosure grounds.
- **'The claim is not covered.'** Quote the exact clause. If the rejection relies on an exclusion that is vague or buried, say so - ambiguity in a standard-form contract is usually read against the insurer.
- **'Delay in intimating the claim.'** A delay alone is not a valid reason to reject unless the policy makes it a condition precedent and the insurer can show it was prejudiced. Say that in your rebuttal.

Telecom and broadband

The service provider is responsible first; TRAI and the Department of Telecom sit above them.

1. Complain to your operator: dial 198 (or 121) or use the app, and get a docket number.
2. If unresolved, escalate to the operator's nodal officer, then to its appellate authority - every operator must publish both.
3. If still unresolved, complain to TRAI through its Complaint Management System and the Telecom Consumers Complaint Monitoring System; email advqos@trai.gov.in.
4. For unwanted promotional calls and messages, register on the Do Not Disturb portal at dnd.trai.gov.in.
5. For value-added services you never asked for, TRAI's CMS lets you see which VAS are active and claim the cost of a month's VAS where double consent was not recorded.

Airlines: your money back on the tarmac

India's DGCA rules fix exactly how much an airline owes you for a denied boarding, a cancellation or a long delay. Quote these numbers in your complaint.

Situation	What you are owed	Limit
Denied boarding - alternate flight within 24 hrs	200% of one-way basic fare plus fuel charge	Rs. 10,000
Denied boarding - alternate flight after 24 hrs	400% of one-way basic fare plus fuel charge	Rs. 20,000
Denied boarding - you decline the alternate flight	Full refund plus 400% of basic fare and fuel charge	Rs. 20,000
Cancellation without the required notice	Rs. 5,000 / Rs. 7,500 / Rs. 10,000 by block time, plus full refund	As shown
Delay over 6 hours	Option of an alternate flight within 6 hours, or a full refund	-
Long delay or overnight delay	Free meals and refreshments, and hotel accommodation with transfers	-

Airlines do not owe compensation where the disruption was caused by extraordinary circumstances beyond their control - weather, ATC decisions, security risks, riots or natural disasters. The burden of proving that the passenger was properly informed of a delay rests with the airline. File first with the airline's nodal officer, then on the AirSewa portal (airsewa.gov.in) run by the Ministry of Civil Aviation, and then with the consumer commission if the airline ignores you.

Trains, food, real estate, securities and the long tail

Railways

For refunds, cleanliness, catering or staff behaviour, use RailMadad - dial 139 or file on the RailMadad portal. It is the Railways' own grievance system and gives you a reference number to escalate with.

Food and restaurants

For unsafe, stale or mislabelled food, complain to the FSSAI through its consumer grievance channel, and to the NCH, which lists Food as a top complaint sector (1,04,218 complaints in 2025-26). Keep the bill and, if you fell ill, the medical record.

Couriers and logistics

Lost, damaged or delayed parcels are a frequent complaint. Complain first to the courier's customer care and nodal officer with the consignment number and proof of value. Most courier terms cap liability low unless you declared the value, so declare it for anything valuable - that declaration is what lets you claim the full amount. Escalate to the NCH, which lists Agency Services (which includes couriers) among the top ten complaint sectors. For an e-commerce shipment, the platform's grievance officer is usually the faster route.

LPG, electricity and utility bills

For a wrong or inflated electricity bill, ask your distribution company (discom) for the meter reading and a re-check; for LPG, complain to the distributor and then to the oil-marketing company. Utility complaints can also go to the NCH and, for state electricity matters, to the state electricity regulatory commission's consumer grievance forum. Keep the bill, the payment receipt and the complaint number.

Real estate and builders

If the project is registered with the state RERA, file a complaint before that authority under Section 31 - use the state's online RERA portal (find it via rera.gov.in). MahaRERA, for example, requires a Form A complaint, offers a conciliation forum first, allows a review within 45 days of an order, and can issue a recovery warrant through the district collector if the builder does not pay. RERA can order the builder to pay interest for every month of delay. You can also file with the consumer commission - the two routes are separate, so pick the faster one.

Investments and securities

Complain first to the listed company, broker or intermediary. If unresolved, file on SEBI's SCORES 2.0 at scores.sebi.gov.in. Complaints are auto-routed to the entity and auto-escalated if not resolved within 21 calendar days. There is a two-level review - first with the designated body, then with SEBI - each within 15 days of the action-taken report. File within one year of the cause of action.

The rest of the long tail

Sector	First forum	Then escalate to
Automobiles and service centres	Dealer / manufacturer	NCH, then consumer commission
Education, coaching and edtech	Institution's grievance cell	NCH, UGC/AICTE where applicable, consumer commission
Healthcare and hospitals	Hospital grievance officer	State medical council / clinical establishment authority, consumer commission
Travel agents and hotels	The agency	NCH (Travel & Tourism is a top-10 sector), consumer commission
Cyber financial fraud	Call 1930 at once	cybercrime.gov.in, then your bank and the RBI Ombudsman
Any government service	The department	CPGRAMS at pgportal.gov.in

Cyber fraud is different - act in the first 24 hours

If money was taken from your account through fraud, do not start with a complaint - start with a call. Dial 1930 immediately and file on cybercrime.gov.in. The faster you report, the better the chance the transaction is frozen before the money leaves the system. Only then work the bank and the RBI Ombudsman angle.

PART FIVE

The consumer court, end to end

The consumer commission is India's most accessible court. You can file online, you often pay nothing, and you can argue your own case. Here is exactly how it works.

The three tiers and where your case belongs

The commission that hears your case depends on the value of the goods or services you paid for as consideration - not on the compensation you claim. The Supreme Court upheld this basis in 2025.

Commission	Consideration paid	Filing fee
District Commission	Up to Rs. 50 lakh	Nil up to Rs. 5 lakh; Rs. 200 up to Rs. 10 lakh; Rs. 400 up to Rs. 20 lakh; Rs. 1,000 up to Rs. 50 lakh
State Commission	Above Rs. 50 lakh up to Rs. 2 crore	Rs. 2,000 up to Rs. 1 crore; Rs. 2,500 up to Rs. 2 crore
National Commission	Above Rs. 2 crore	Rs. 3,000 to Rs. 7,500 by value

The single most useful fact here: for a dispute where the amount paid is up to Rs. 5 lakh - which covers the overwhelming majority of everyday complaints - the filing fee is nil.

The two deadlines you cannot ignore

- **File within two years** of the date the cause of action arose. If you are late, you must file an application for condonation of delay explaining why, and the commission may or may not accept it.
- **Where you file:** at the commission with jurisdiction over your place of residence or work - not the seller's. This was a deliberate pro-consumer change, so you no longer travel to the company's city.

Documents to gather before you file

- Invoice or receipt, and proof of payment
- The order confirmation and any warranty or policy document
- Your written complaint to the seller and its reply, if any
- Screenshots, chats, emails and call records
- A short, signed 'synopsis' of facts and a notarised affidavit
- A memo of parties (names and addresses of both sides) and a vakalatnama only if a lawyer appears for you

Filing on e-Jagriti, step by step

1. Register on the e-Jagriti portal (e-jagriti.gov.in) and log in.
2. Choose 'File New Case', then 'Consumer Complaint'.
3. Read the document list and the fee that applies to your value, and pay the fee online if one is due.
4. Enter the case details - amount paid, claim amount, date of cause of action, state, district and category.
5. Enter your details and the opposite party's details.
6. Upload the index, synopsis, memo of parties, your notarised affidavit, the vakalatnama (if any) and the annexures of evidence.
7. Select the commission, preview, and submit. You get a reference number - print it.

What happens after you file

- Admissibility is decided within 21 days of filing - if it is not, the complaint is deemed admissible.
- Every effort is made to decide the complaint within three months of the opposite party receiving notice, or five months if the goods need testing.
- You can request a video-conference hearing, so travel is optional.
- Either side may opt for mediation, which is free and often faster than a full hearing.

Appeals

If you lose, or the other side does, an appeal lies to the next tier. In practice the window is short: an appeal from a District Commission order goes to the State Commission, and from the State to the National Commission. Diarise the date of the order and act within the appeal period - do not wait for the written copy to arrive by post.

Enforcing an order you won

A commission's order is enforceable like a court decree. If the other side does not comply, apply to the same commission for execution. For a RERA order, non-compliance can trigger a recovery warrant to the district collector. For a commission order, persistent non-compliance can attract penalties and, ultimately, attachment of property.

Do you need a lawyer?

No - a consumer can appear in person at every tier, and many do. A lawyer helps in large or technical cases, but for a refund or replacement claim up to a few lakh rupees, a clear complaint and good documents usually matter more than legal representation. Never pay an 'agent' who promises a result for a fee.

Mediation and online dispute resolution

Not every dispute needs a hearing. With both parties' consent, a commission can refer a case to mediation under the Mediation Rules, 2020. Mediation is free, faster than a full hearing, and produces a settlement both sides accept. In the securities market, SEBI's SCORES links to the smartodr.in online dispute resolution platform for the same reason. If the other side is willing to talk, mediation is often the quickest route to your money.

How much you can actually get

A commission can award a refund of the amount paid, interest on it, compensation for the loss you suffered, compensation for mental agony and inconvenience, and the cost of the complaint. The one discipline that matters: keep the numbers proportionate and evidenced. A claim for a refund plus a modest, explained compensation figure is far more likely to succeed than a round-number claim for lakhs with nothing behind it.

Appeals: short windows, so diarise the date

An appeal from one tier goes to the next - District to State, State to National, and from the National Commission to the Supreme Court. The Act sets short windows (broadly 30 to 45 days depending on the tier), so note the date of the order the day you receive it and confirm the exact period with the commission. Waiting for the written copy to arrive by post is how appeals are lost.

Drafting a complaint that wins

A consumer complaint is judged on clarity and evidence, not length. Build it in six blocks: who you are; what you bought and paid; what the seller did wrong; what the law or contract says; what proof you attach; and what you want. Attach every document you refer to and number them.

What you can ask for

- Refund of the amount paid, with interest
- Replacement of the goods, or repair of the defect
- Compensation for the loss you suffered because of the defect or delay
- Compensation for mental agony and inconvenience
- The cost of the complaint and any incidental charges
- Discontinuation of the unfair practice, in a class complaint

Six mistakes that lose cases

- Claiming a huge round number with no basis. Ask for what you can justify with documents.
- Mixing unrelated grievances in one complaint.
- Filing in the wrong commission for the value paid.
- Filing after the two-year limit with no explanation.
- Relying on phone calls instead of written evidence.
- Not impleading the right opposite party - for a marketplace purchase, that usually means naming both the platform and the seller.

PART SIX

Twelve ready-to-send complaint letters

Copy these, fill the brackets, and send. Each one is written to create a dated paper trail and to state a deadline and a next step - which is what makes a complaint move.

1. First complaint to an e-commerce grievance officer

Subject: Complaint about order [order no.] - request for refund/replacement

Dear Grievance Officer,
I placed order [order no.] on [date] for [product] and paid Rs. [amount]. The product arrived on [date] and [describe the defect/wrong item/non-delivery]. I attach the invoice, photographs taken on arrival, and the order confirmation. I request a [refund/replacement] of Rs. [amount] within 15 days. Under the E-Commerce Rules, 2020, I expect acknowledgement within 48 hours and resolution within one month. If I do not hear from you, I will register a complaint with the National Consumer Helpline and, if needed, file before the consumer commission.
Regards, [Name, contact, order no.]

2. Escalation to the NCH (what to type)

Sector: E-Commerce. Company: [name]. Order: [no.]. Amount: Rs. [X]. Problem: [two sentences]. Evidence attached: invoice, photos, email to the grievance officer dated [date] with no satisfactory reply. Relief sought: refund of Rs. [X] plus compensation of Rs. [Y].

3. Bank complaint - unauthorised transaction

Subject: Unauthorised transaction of Rs. [X] on account/card [no.] dated [date]

Dear Sir/Madam, I did not authorise a transaction of Rs. [X] on [date] at [time] on my [account/card]. I reported it on [date] and am entitled to zero liability under RBI rules for prompt reporting. I request reversal within 30 days and a written acknowledgement with a complaint number. If I do not get a resolution, I will approach the RBI Ombudsman under the RB-IOS, 2026.
Regards, [Name, account no.]

4. RBI Ombudsman complaint (cms.rbi.org.in)

Complainant details, bank and branch, the complaint number and date of your complaint to the bank, the transaction details and reference number, the facts, the loss, the relief sought, and a list of the documents attached (bank complaint and acknowledgement, statement, screenshots). File within 90 days of the bank's failure or unsatisfactory reply.

5. Insurance claim rejection rebuttal

Subject: Rebuttal to claim rejection for policy [no.], claim [no.]

Dear Grievance Redressal Officer, your letter dated [date] rejects my claim on the ground of [reason]. I respectfully disagree: [state why, quoting the clause and the facts]. I attach [documents]. I request reconsideration within 14 days; failing which I will escalate to IRDAI through Bima Bharosa and to the Insurance Ombudsman.
Regards, [Name, policy no.]

6. Insurance Ombudsman complaint

Name and address of complainant; the insurer and branch; the facts and the policy; the nature and extent of loss; the relief sought (not exceeding Rs. 50 lakh); a declaration that the same matter is not pending before any court or consumer forum; and copies of the policy, the rejection letter and your representation to the insurer. File within one year.

7. Telecom billing dispute

Subject: Disputed charges of Rs. [X] on number [no.] for [period]

Dear Sir/Madam, my bill for [period] includes charges of Rs. [X] that I did not incur or authorise, namely [describe]. I request a detailed call and data record, reversal of the disputed amount, and a written reply within 15 days. If unresolved, I will escalate to your nodal officer and appellate authority and then to TRAI.
Regards, [Name, number]

8. Airline compensation claim

Subject: Compensation for [denied boarding/cancellation/delay] on flight [no.] dated [date]

Dear Nodal Officer, I held a confirmed ticket on flight [no.] dated [date] and was [denied boarding/cancelled/delayed] by [hours]. As per DGCA CAR, Section 3, Series M, Part IV, I am entitled to Rs. [amount]. I request payment within 15 days. Failing this, I will file on AirSewa and before the consumer commission.
Regards, [Name, PNR]

9. Builder delay complaint to RERA

Register on your state RERA portal and file under Section 31 in the prescribed form (for example, Form A in Maharashtra). State the agreement date, the promised possession date, the amount paid, and the delay. Ask for interest for every month of delay and, if you choose, a refund with interest. Attach the agreement, payment receipts and the possession letter.

10. SEBI SCORES complaint

Register on SCORES 2.0, select the category and the entity, describe the grievance with supporting documents, and submit. Note the registration number. Expect resolution within 21 days, with a two-level review if you are not satisfied.

11. Legal notice before filing in the commission

Subject: Legal notice for [refund/compensation] - [order/account no.]

Under instructions from and on behalf of my client [name], I serve you this notice. Despite [describe the transaction and the failure] and my client's complaint dated [date], you have failed to [refund/replace/compensate]. You are called upon to pay Rs. [X] within 15 days of receipt, failing which my client will file a complaint before the consumer commission, claiming the amount plus compensation, interest and costs, entirely at your risk as to costs and consequences.
[Signature, date, place]

12. Follow-up when everyone goes quiet

Subject: Second reminder - complaint [no.] dated [date] remains unresolved

I wrote to you on [date] about [issue] and have had no substantive reply. As [X] days have passed, I am treating this as a refusal to redress. I am now escalating to [the NCH / the RBI Ombudsman / the consumer commission]. I am copying this correspondence to that forum as evidence.
Regards, [Name]

13. Food safety complaint to FSSAI

Subject: Complaint about unsafe or mislabelled food from [outlet/product]

I purchased [product/meal] from [outlet] on [date] (bill no. [no.]). [Describe the problem - stale, contaminated, mislabelled, or a foreign object]. I attach the bill and photographs. I request an investigation and appropriate action under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.
Regards, [Name]

14. Hospital or clinic billing grievance

Subject: Disputed charges of Rs. [X] on bill [no.] dated [date]

I was treated at [hospital] on [date]. My bill of Rs. [X] includes charges of Rs. [Y] for [items] that were not agreed, not explained, or not provided. I request a detailed, itemised bill and a refund of the disputed amount within 15 days. Failing this, I will approach the hospital's grievance officer, the state health authority and the consumer commission.
Regards, [Name]

15. Telecom value-added service refund

Subject: Refund of value-added service charges on number [no.]

My bill for [period] shows VAS charges of Rs. [X] for services I did not request or consent to. Under TRAI rules, where double consent was not recorded I am entitled to a refund of one month's VAS cost. I request reversal and a written reply within 15 days, failing which I will raise the matter through TRAI's Complaint Management System.
Regards, [Name, number]

16. Public grievance on CPGRAMS

Subject: Grievance against [department/office]

I applied for [service] on [date] and have received no response. My reference number is [no.]. I request [the specific action] within a reasonable time. I attach the application and acknowledgement.
Regards, [Name, address]

The six-line rule for any complaint

You do not need a template for every situation. Any complaint, in any sector, can be written in six lines: what I bought, when, and the reference number; what I paid; what went wrong; the proof I am attaching; what I want, with an amount and a date; and what I will do next if I do not hear back. Master those six lines and you can file at every rung of the ladder - from a WhatsApp message to a full consumer-commission complaint.

PART SEVEN

The 30-day action plan, and the traps

Complaints are won by rhythm, not by anger. Follow this plan and you will be through every free rung in a month, with a complete record ready for the commission if you need it.

The 30-day plan

Day	Action	Done
1	Gather every document - invoice, order, warranty, chats - into one folder.	
2	Send the first written complaint to the seller's grievance officer with a 15-day deadline.	
3	Save the acknowledgement and note the complaint number.	
4-14	Do not chase. Let the clock run. Note any reply and whether it meets your ask.	
15	If unresolved, file on the National Consumer Helpline the same day.	
16-30	If it is a bank, insurer or broker, move to the sector ombudsman once its window opens.	
30	If still unresolved, prepare the consumer-commission complaint and file on e-Jagriti.	
Ongoing	Diarise every deadline. Escalate on the date, never after it.	

The red flags: what to watch for before you buy

Prevention beats redressal. These are the signals that a seller is about to become a problem.

- **A price that is too good.** If a discount beats every legitimate seller, the product is likely fake, refurbished or never coming.
- **No grievance officer details.** Every legitimate e-commerce entity must publish them. Their absence is itself a breach.
- **Pressure to pay outside the platform.** Any request to pay by UPI to a personal number or to 'confirm the order' off-platform removes your protections.
- **Only five-star reviews, all in one week.** A wall of perfect reviews is often a wall of bought ones.
- **A free trial that wants your card.** The trial is the product; the subscription is the trap.
- **'Prior price' games.** A '70% off' that was never sold at the higher price. From 1 January 2027, the law requires the true 30-day lowest price to be shown.

Eight traps that quietly kill complaints

1. Deleting the WhatsApp chat or clearing the email thread before you have exported it.
2. Accepting a 'goodwill voucher' as a full settlement when you wanted a refund.
3. Complaining to the seller's social-media handle instead of its grievance officer - there is no paper trail.
4. Waiting for the 'right moment' and drifting past the two-year limit.
5. Filing in the wrong commission for the value you paid.
6. Paying an 'agent' to file what you can file free.
7. Not naming both the platform and the seller in an e-commerce complaint.
8. Assuming a verbal promise counts. It does not.

The one habit that decides everything

> Before you buy anything worth more than a few thousand rupees online, take thirty seconds to screenshot the listing, the price and the seller's details. That single screenshot is the difference between a case and a story.

PART EIGHT

Five disputes, start to finish

These worked examples show the ladder in motion. They are illustrations to adapt to your own facts, not legal advice.

1. A Rs. 4,000 phone arrives cracked

1. Day 1: Photograph the cracked phone in the unopened box and raise a replacement request in the app.
2. Day 2: Email the platform's grievance officer with the order number, photos and the ask; expect acknowledgement in 48 hours.
3. Day 3: If the reply is a refusal, file on the NCH that week and attach the email trail.
4. Day 30: If the NCH route fails, file on e-Jagriti. Since you paid under Rs. 5 lakh, the fee is nil, and you can ask for the refund plus compensation and costs.

2. A Rs. 1.2 lakh health claim rejected for 'non-disclosure'

1. Write to the insurer's Grievance Redressal Officer, quoting the clause, and expect a reply in 14 days.
2. If the reply stands, register on Bima Bharosa with the policy, proposal form and medical records.
3. If that fails, file with the Insurance Ombudsman within one year. The claim is within the Rs. 50 lakh cap, so it is free, and the award binds the insurer.
4. Keep the consumer commission as the final option if the Ombudsman does not help.

3. An unauthorised Rs. 18,000 UPI debit

1. Report to your bank the same day and get a complaint number - prompt reporting protects your zero-liability position.
2. Wait 30 days. If the money is not restored or the reply is unsatisfactory, file on the RBI Ombudsman portal at cms.rbi.org.in.
3. File within 90 days of the bank's failure or reply. There is no fee.

4. A flight cancelled four hours before departure

1. Note the block time of the flight to work out your entitlement under the DGCA rules - Rs. 5,000, Rs. 7,500 or Rs. 10,000, plus a full refund.
2. File first with the airline's nodal officer; then, if ignored, on AirSewa.
3. If the airline blames weather or ATC, ask it to show that the cause was truly outside its control - the burden of proof is on the airline.

5. A builder delays possession by 18 months

1. File before your state RERA under Section 31 with the agreement, the promised possession date and payment receipts.
2. Ask for interest for every month of delay, and a refund with interest if you prefer to exit.
3. If the builder does not comply with a RERA order, apply for a recovery warrant - RERA can route it through the district collector.

APPENDIX A

Master contact directory

Forum	How to reach it	Cost
National Consumer Helpline	1915 / 1800 11 4000; WhatsApp 8800001915; consumerhelpline.gov.in	Free
Consumer commissions (e-Jagriti)	e-jagriti.gov.in (legacy portal: edaakhil.nic.in)	Free up to Rs. 5 lakh
RBI Ombudsman (RB-IOS, 2026)	cms.rbi.org.in; crpc@rbi.org.in; toll-free 14448	Free
IRDAI Bima Bharosa	bimabharosa.irdai.gov.in; 155255 / 1800 425 4732; complaints@irdai.gov.in	Free
Insurance Ombudsman	cioins.co.in (17 centres); file within one year	Free
SEBI SCORES 2.0	scores.sebi.gov.in; toll-free 1800 266 7575	Free
TRAI / telecom	TRAI Complaint Management System; advqos@trai.gov.in; DND at dnd.trai.gov.in	Free
Airlines	airsewa.gov.in; then the airline's nodal officer and appellate authority	Free
Railways	Dial 139; RailMadad portal	Free
Cyber financial fraud	Dial 1930; cybercrime.gov.in	Free
Any government service	CPGRAMS at pgportal.gov.in	Free

The 13 dark patterns the law now names

If a platform used any of these on you, name it in your complaint - the CCPA treats them as unfair trade practices.

Dark pattern	What it looks like
False urgency	False scarcity or demand to force a quick purchase
Basket sneaking	Items, fees or donations added at checkout without consent
Confirm shaming	Guilt or fear messaging to push a purchase or a subscription
Forced action	Making you buy extra, sign up, or share data to get what you want
Subscription trap	Impossible or complex cancellation; forced auto-debit
Interface interference	Highlighting some facts while hiding other relevant ones
Bait and switch	Advertising one outcome and serving another
Drip pricing	Revealing the true price only in stages or after checkout
Disguised advertisement	Ads masked as user content or news
Nagging	Repeated interruptions and requests to push a transaction
Trick question	Confusing wording or double negatives to steer your choice
SaaS billing	Silently converting a free trial to a paid recurring plan
Rogue malware	Scareware claiming a virus to sell fake protection

Appendix B: Fee, timeline and deadline tables

Filing fees (Consumer Protection (CDRC) Rules, 2020, as amended 2023)

Value of goods/services paid as consideration	Fee
Up to Rs. 5 lakh	Nil
Above Rs. 5 lakh up to Rs. 10 lakh	Rs. 200
Above Rs. 10 lakh up to Rs. 20 lakh	Rs. 400
Above Rs. 20 lakh up to Rs. 50 lakh	Rs. 1,000
Above Rs. 50 lakh up to Rs. 1 crore	Rs. 2,000
Above Rs. 1 crore up to Rs. 2 crore	Rs. 2,500
Above Rs. 2 crore	Rs. 3,000 to Rs. 7,500 by value

Deadlines that decide cases

Clock	Length	Applies to
Acknowledge an e-commerce complaint	48 hours	E-commerce grievance officer
Resolve an e-commerce complaint	1 month	E-commerce grievance officer
Resolve an insurance grievance	14 days	Insurer's Grievance Redressal Officer
Wait before the RBI Ombudsman	30 days	After complaining to the bank
File with the RBI Ombudsman	90 days	From the bank's failure or reply
File with the Insurance Ombudsman	1 year	From rejection or one month of silence
File on SEBI SCORES	1 year	From the cause of action
File in a consumer commission	2 years	From the cause of action

Appendix C: Twenty frequently asked questions

Do I need a lawyer for a consumer complaint? No. You can file and argue in person at every tier, and most small claims are handled without one.

How much does it cost to file? Nothing for claims where you paid up to Rs. 5 lakh. Above that, fees start at Rs. 200 and rise with the amount.

Where do I file? At the commission covering your place of residence or work, not the seller's.

How long does a case take? The law aims for three months (five if testing is needed), though real timelines vary by commission.

Can I file online? Yes - e-Jagriti handles filing, notices, hearings and orders.

What if I am late? File an application for condonation of delay with reasons; the commission decides whether to accept it.

Can I claim compensation for mental agony? Yes - the Act allows compensation for loss and for mental agony and inconvenience.

The company offered a voucher instead of a refund. Must I accept? No. You can insist on the remedy you asked for and escalate if it is refused.

My UPI transfer went to the wrong person. What now? Report to your bank at once, then to the RBI Ombudsman if the bank does not act within 30 days.

The insurer rejected my claim. What is my first step? Write to the insurer's Grievance Redressal Officer and expect a reply within 14 days.

What is Bima Bharosa? IRDAI's free portal for monitoring and resolving insurance grievances across the industry.

Is the Insurance Ombudsman free? Yes, and its award binds the insurer, which must comply within 30 days.

Can I use both the Ombudsman and the consumer court? Not on the same matter at the same time - pick one route.

The airline cancelled my flight. What am I owed? A refund and compensation of Rs. 5,000 to Rs. 10,000 by block time, unless the cause was extraordinary.

My builder has delayed possession. Where do I go? Your state RERA under Section 31 - it can order interest for every month of delay.

Do I complain to SEBI or the company first? The company or intermediary first, then SEBI's SCORES if unresolved.

What is the NCH good for? Fast, free, pre-litigation resolution - especially strong on e-commerce, food and retail.

Does the NCH order refunds? It cannot order them, but it routes complaints to companies that must respond, and it has facilitated over Rs. 91 crore in refunds.

Can I complain about an advertisement? Yes - to the CCPA, which can fine a manufacturer or endorser and order an ad to be stopped.

What is a dark pattern? A design trick that pushes you into a choice you did not intend - the law now names 13 of them.

Appendix D: Glossary and pre-filing checklist

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Consumer	A person who buys goods or hires services for a consideration, other than for a commercial purpose.
Unfair trade practice	A deceptive practice used to promote a sale.
Unfair contract	A one-sided term in a standard-form contract that favours the seller.
CCPA	Central Consumer Protection Authority - the regulator that acts for consumers as a class.
NCH	National Consumer Helpline - the free pre-litigation grievance platform.
e-Jagriti	The unified online platform for consumer commissions across India.
INGRAM	The integrated grievance redressal mechanism behind the NCH.
RB-IOS 2026	The Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2026, in force from 1 July 2026.
Dark pattern	A user-interface design that manipulates a consumer into an unintended choice.
Pecuniary jurisdiction	The value limit that decides which tier of commission hears your case.

Evidence pack by sector

Sector	What to keep ready
E-commerce	Invoice, arrival photos, listing screenshots, return request, grievance email
Banking / UPI	Statement entry, transaction reference, bank acknowledgement, complaint date
Insurance	Policy, proposal form, claim documents, rejection letter, your representation
Telecom	Bill, the disputed charges, the operator's docket number
Airlines	Ticket or PNR, delay or cancellation notice, proof you were denied boarding
Real estate	Agreement, payment receipts, promised versus actual possession date
Securities	Contract note, holding statement, correspondence with the broker

Pre-filing checklist

- I complained in writing to the seller and kept the acknowledgement.
- I have the invoice, proof of payment and the order or account number.
- I have photographs or screenshots taken at the time of the problem.
- I have the complaint number from the NCH or the sector ombudsman, if I used one.
- I am within the two-year limit, or I have a reason for the delay.
- I am filing in the commission that matches the amount I paid.
- I have named both the platform and the seller, where a marketplace was involved.
- I have stated exactly what I want - refund, replacement, compensation and costs.

When the seller is outside India

If you bought from a foreign seller or flew a foreign airline, your options are narrower but not empty. A foreign carrier operating to or from India is covered by the DGCA rules on denied boarding, cancellation and delay, and complaints go to AirSewa. For a card purchase from a foreign merchant, ask your bank to raise a chargeback under the card network's rules - keep the order, the tracking and your attempts to contact the seller. For a foreign online seller, a consumer commission can still hear the case if the seller has a presence in India or the transaction was completed here, though enforcing an order abroad is hard. As always, the first step is a written complaint and a clean paper trail.

Appendix E: A worked complaint, written out in full

This is a complete consumer-commission complaint for a defective product. Replace the bracketed parts and attach the documents it refers to.

Before the District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, [District, State]

Complainant: [Name, address, mobile, email]
Opposite Party 1: [Seller name and address]
Opposite Party 2: [Platform name and address, if bought on a marketplace]
Complaint under Section 35 of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019

1. The complainant is a 'consumer' within the meaning of the Act, having purchased [product] for personal use and not for any commercial purpose.
2. On [date], the complainant placed order no. [no.] with the opposite parties and paid Rs. [amount]. The invoice is attached.
3. The product was delivered on [date] and was [describe the defect]. Photographs taken on arrival are attached.
4. The complainant raised a return or refund request on [date] and emailed the grievance officer on [date]. The opposite party [refused / did not reply]. The correspondence is attached.
5. The opposite party has therefore committed a deficiency in service and an unfair trade practice, and the complainant is entitled to relief.
6. Prayer: the complainant prays that the Commission direct the opposite parties to (a) refund Rs. [amount] with interest; (b) pay Rs. [amount] as compensation for mental agony and inconvenience; and (c) pay the cost of this complaint.

Verification: I, [name], verify that the contents above are true to my knowledge and belief. **List of documents:** 1. Invoice. 2. Photographs on arrival. 3. Email to the grievance officer. 4. Return-request screenshot.

Appendix F: The one-page quick reference card

Tear this out, or save it to your phone. It is the whole playbook in one screen.

Forum	Reach it at	The clock
National Consumer Helpline	1915 / WhatsApp 8800001915 / consumerhelpline.gov.in	File any time
Consumer commission	e-jagriti.gov.in	Within 2 years
RBI Ombudsman	cms.rbi.org.in / toll-free 14448	Within 90 days
IRDAI Bima Bharosa	bimabharosa.irdai.gov.in / 155255	After 14 days
Insurance Ombudsman	cioins.co.in	Within 1 year
SEBI SCORES 2.0	scores.sebi.gov.in	Within 1 year

Forum	Reach it at	The clock
Airlines	airsewa.gov.in	After the airline's nodal officer
Cyber financial fraud	Dial 1930 / cybercrime.gov.in	Immediately

The numbers to remember

Filing fee in a consumer commission: **nil** up to Rs. 5 lakh paid. NCH acknowledgement for e-commerce: **48 hours**. Insurance grievance: **14 days**. Bank, before the RBI Ombudsman: **30 days**. The ladder is free at rungs two and three - never pay an agent.

Sources

Every figure, fee, deadline and portal in this playbook is drawn from official Government of India and regulator sources, current as of October 2026:

- Department of Consumer Affairs - consumeraffairs.gov.in and consumerhelpline.gov.in
- National Consumer Helpline - consumerhelpline.gov.in (channels, INGRAM, convergence)
- e-Jagriti consumer commission platform - e-jagriti.gov.in (legacy: edaakhil.nic.in)
- The Consumer Protection Act, 2019 and the rules made under it
- Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020 and the (Amendment) Rules, 2026
- Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023
- Lok Sabha and PIB releases on NCH, CCPA and consumer-commission performance
- Reserve Bank of India - RB-IOS, 2026 FAQ at rbi.org.in
- IRDAI - Bima Bharosa (bimabharosa.irdai.gov.in) and the Insurance Ombudsman (cioins.co.in)
- SEBI - SCORES 2.0 at scores.sebi.gov.in
- DGCA - CAR Section 3, Series M, Part IV; AirSewa at airsewa.gov.in
- TRAI - Complaint Management System and the DND portal
- RERA - state authorities via rera.gov.in

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